

ADDITIONAL HARRINGTON NOTES ON THE "LONE WOMAN"

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INTWO PREVIOUS ISSUES OF THE MASTERKEY (Vol. 52, Nos. 1 & 4, 1978) several exciting discoveries of ethnographic notes pertaining to the "Lone Woman" of San Nicolas Island were reported. These notes were found among the extensive papers of John P. Harrington for the Ventureño Chumash. Recently, however, two additional notes on the "Lone Woman" have surfaced among Harrington's papers for the Barbareño Chumash. Interviewed in Santa Barbara some time between 1912 and 1922, the informant in this case was Luisa Ygnacio, a full-blood Barbareño Chumash who was baptized at Mission Santa Barbara about 1830. Harrington used the abbreviation "Sa." and "La." when referring to her (Blackburn 1975:19).

The first short note is as follows:

"Sa. has never seen a shell fishhook, except the one that the last woman of San Nicolas had. It was a big shell fishhook, and [the] fishline [with it] was as thick as a lead pencil. Sa.'s spouse brought it.' Sa. had it at Sa.'s home on the ranch, but after a while it got thrown away. Sa. also had at the ranch two feather capes belonging to the last woman of San Nicolas which Sa.'s spouse brought at the same time that he brought the fishhook.' These were small (not big) and were made by sewing together seagull skins with [the] feathers still on, Sa. thinks. [The] feathers [were] on [the]

outside [of the capes]. Used them [by wearing them] thrown over [the] shoulders. When Sa.'s spouse died, Sa. threw the capes and hook away.³

The second note mentions these details concerning the woman:

"They had the last woman of San Nicolas Island here in Santa Barbara. Sa. did not go to see her, but many people did. Martina went to see her, and either Martina or others said she talked like a Fernandino.⁴ So they got Pilar to come and try to talk with her.⁵ Pilar talked good Barbareño Chumash, but she never forgot her native tongue and talked it when the Fernandinos came here to Santa Barbara. Pilar tried to talk with the woman in Fernandino, but she said she could not understand.⁶

"If they had let the woman stay with the Indians here, she would have been all right. But they kept her with Qorqe (George Nidever). Martina and Pilar came from Ventura one time and got some clams and maybe some other things on the road, and when they passed by here, in Santa Barbara, they visited the woman and gave her the clams. The woman was greatly pleased. Martina and Pilar had just made a little trip to Ventura. Sa. thinks they had seen the woman before that time."

End Notes

1. In 1853, when the "Lone Woman" was taken off the island and brought to Santa Barbara, Luisa Ygnacio would have been about 23 years old. She married Policarpio, also Chumash, in 1851 (Blackburn 1975:19). According to other Harrington notes, Policarpio was a fisherman residing in an Indian community of fishermen at Goleta Estero, just west of Santa Barbara. His father was Jose Sudon *Kamuliyatset*, a Santa Cruz Island Indian baptized on July 29, 1819 at Mission Santa Barbara. *Kamuliyatset* was the captain of the Goleta village where he resided and was also the owner of a Chumash plank canoe which was used in the Chumash Revolt of 1824 (Hudson 1976).

2. A feather dress was reported for the woman, described as made of several square-cut shag skins sown together (Dittman 1973:1; Nidever 1973:10). The dress was also described

to Harrington years later by a Mr. and Mrs. del Valle, "old Santa Barbara residents," which in his notes is described as follows:

"They said that the woman had an apron of fiber on underneath her duckskin cloak. The dress which she wore was of shag, not duckskins. Feathers were all around the hem. They all faced the same way. The skins were neatly joined. They said it was a beautiful piece of work. The dress had holes for the arms. It reached almost to her knees. The one she wore appeared not to be finished."

The dress was reportedly sent to Rome by Father Gonzalez Rubio of Mission Santa Barbara. The description of the cape's manufacture is similar to that of the dress, and it is also suggestive of the Seri Indian bird-skin robes made by sewing pelican skins together.

3. The word "brought" suggests that perhaps Policarpio, like Malquiare in the Ventureño accounts, was an Indian crewman serving with George Nidever on the voyage which brought the woman off the island (Hudson 1978a:26; 1978b:152-153). Both Dittman (1973:1) and Nidever (1973:10) mention their crew as being composed of Mission Indians. Policarpio, a resident fisherman of the Santa Barbara region at the time (and perhaps an experienced otter hunter) would certainly have been an ideal crewman. His death took place sometime prior to 1856 (Blackburn 1975:19).

4. Martina *Lekte* was a Santa Cruz Island woman born at *Kaxas* (Prisoner's Harbor) and brought to the mainland at Santa Barbara while still a child. She was a niece of Cecilia, the wife of *Kamuliyatset*. Martina was married twice and lived for a time in Ventura (Hudson 1979a:149).

5. Pilar, according to Luisa Ygnacio, was first married to Teofilo, a brother of Policarpio. Thus Pilar and Luisa were sisters-in-law. Following Teofilo's death Pilar married Justo of Ventura, a distant relative of *Kamuliyatset's* wife Cecilia. Prior to Pilar's death Justo fled to the Tulare country with a Ventura woman named Encelaria. Pilar is buried at the Mission Santa Barbara cemetery.

6. In Ventureño accounts Harrington's informant reported that the woman could understand Fernandino (Hudson

1978a:25, 1978b:153). We are now told that she was unable to understand the language. Possibly then, her language, Nicoleño, was distinct enough from Fernandino so as not to be understood at all. A likely choice might be that Nicoleño was either a language of its own or a dialect of Gabrielino spoken on Santa Cruz Island. One of Harrington's Gabrielino informants, Jose de los Santos Juncos, from the mainland, stated that the people of San Gabriel could not be understood by those of Catalina Island (Hudson 1979b:361). It would therefore seem that "Catalineño" was a separate Gabrielino language, as might also be the case for Nicoleño.

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